MINIMUM VIABLE PRODUCT (MVP)



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SUPER GUIDE:

MINIMUM VIABLE PRODUCT (MVP)

BY DANIEL PEREIRA

THE BUSINESS MODEL ANALYST

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INTRODUCTION

Are you thinking about starting the idea for your startup, but have no clue how to proceed? Or are you currently building a minimum viable product (MVP), but find it unclear what to do next? This Minimum Viable Product super guide is designed to help you understand the core philosophies of an MVP and how to apply them in a real-life situation. It will take some of the guesswork out of your product development process, leaving you with more time to focus on the product and its iterative development.

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WHAT IS A MINIMUM VIABLE PRODUCT (MVP)

An MVP, in the world of business, is a product with all the basic features it needs to offer, but without additional bells and whistles. The point of an MVP is to get a product out into the market and the hands of consumers as soon as possible so that they can give feedback on what they like and what they don't, which helps guide the company in improving the product.

The MVP approach to developing new products is premised on the idea that you first produce a real product — in other words, something that's functional and is not just a technical prototype or an imaginary idea. The goal with an MVP is to have a product in hand that you can then show to customers and users and see what they do with it — a much closer approximation of market reality than asking people what they would do.

A MINIMUM VIABLE PRODUCT IS MINIMAL

The origin of the term minimum viable product (MVP) can be traced back to lean manufacturing principles. Those original principles from Toyota were about producing a valuable product (in this case, cars) with the least amount of waste possible. A lean manufacturing process should eliminate

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unused parts and reduce the need for workers to carry them around. Even items kept in storage and not being actively used in the production process were considered waste, so a minimum viable product should be about reducing waste.

For a startup, this means taking the least amount of time, effort, and cost in the development of an MVP. Waste in this case might mean time spent developing features that don't contribute to getting your product to market as quickly as possible.

How “Minimum” Should an MVP Be?
An MVP should contain only the most valuable features and, perhaps most importantly, be fully functional. A full product should be released, that is, without low-quality graphics, glitches in the interface, or functionality crashes. Rushing to complete an application can kill an MVP before it even has a chance to succeed.

A good minimum viable product must have all the core features that communicate value, a well-designed user experience, and solid reliability.

A MINIMUM VIABLE PRODUCT IS VIABLE

One of the main goals of an MVP is to deliver on what the customer had been promised, but if the company mainly wants to use this as a learning opportunity (or "beta test") to refine their product and market, then that’s not necessary.

A good explainer video should detail the value proposition of your product as a way to show prospects what your product has to offer them. Not only does this make it easier for people

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to decide whether they will buy your product or not, but it also shows you what the customers are looking for in a product that the company is providing.

A MINIMUM VIABLE PRODUCT IS A PRODUCT

That's not a must, though. Since a prototype or MVP is a way of testing if a service is viable or if an idea or web design will work for your customers, it can be in any form if that form satisfies its goals of acquiring user feedback.

Lean Startup was developed on the Customer Development Model by Steve Blank, an approach where you talk to customers as a way of learning customer needs as quickly and inexpensively as possible. Steve believes that this way of working is also the simplest and most effective.

Even though just talking to customers is not a product, because minimum viable products allow you to collect the most validated learning about customers with the least effort, activities that can guarantee customer feedback help you quickly gather information. Such activity can be talking to customers and seeing what they consider valuable in a product, or launching a prototype through which you can measure feature usage and gather customer feedback.

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MVP IS NOT A PRODUCT, IT'S A PROCESS

An MVP (minimum viable product) is not just a product with key features that you consider core to your business. It’s also not just a “shippable” product; instead, it’s part of a process for determining what your target market really needs. Plus, it doesn’t have to be a physical product — it can be an email or website prototype — and it doesn’t have to exist only once. Instead, you can develop one MVP after the next, each time learning more about what works best for your audience.

An MVP is a process of testing your ideas and assumptions. It's an iterative process that involves making calculated risks, running small experiments, and implementing changes based on the results.

The challenge of product building is that your assumptions may be wrong. You have to design in a way that allows for this possibility, even if it means you may have to iterate many times or backtrack.

This is true in any creative domain. Every writer knows that producing good, publishable writing is not a one-time task. Writers have to create and edit many drafts before they've produced work they can be proud of, just as coders have to restructure and rewrite code repeatedly before it becomes clear and concise.

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MINIMUM VIABLE PRODUCT CASE STUDY

- **Dropbox**
  The application, when installed, automatically creates a Dropbox folder on the computer's desktop. Anything that is dragged to it will be uploaded to the company's servers and become available on all of a user's connected devices. The founders of Dropbox found it difficult to explain the concept of the product to investors. To test whether users would want to use their service, an explainer video MVP was used before moving forward with development. The concept of the service drew drastic attention from users, which ultimately led to Dropbox receiving funding for the development of its product. Through the success of its MVP and its main product, Dropbox is now worth about $8 billion.

- **Intruit**
  Since Intuit transitioned from selling shrink-wrapped desktop software to offering software-as-a-service, many of its business model elements had to change. During their transition, they adopted the MVP model to understand the market they were heading into. They also used small improvements to their business model to test market assumptions while maintaining the core features of their MVP.

  When Intruit was transitioning from a traditional hosting platform to a new application technology, the innovation team had to understand how they would deliver value through a new distribution channel and marketing message, and how they would capture

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value through a subscription pricing model to create value. Their ultimate understanding of this and building upon that led Intruit to its position as one of the main actors in the financial tech world of today.

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HISTORY OF MVP

The concept of the minimum viable product originated in 2001, when Frank Robinson and Eric Ries began using the term.

Frank Robinson believed in developing a product big enough to be a sound launching pad for a company's next products, but not so small that a competitor can easily influence the market.

Steve Blank, a college lecturer, just like Ries, defined MVP as an essential component of the lean startup method.

The lean startup method of creating business is based on the principle that it's better to create a product and get it out into the marketplace as soon as possible, even if it isn't perfect. By getting a product on the market, you can start to learn from customers and iterate the product based on their feedback.

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RELATED CONCEPTS TO THE MINIMUM VIABLE PRODUCT

Here are the most common terms, concepts, and phrases related to the minimum viable product (MVP):

PROTOTYPE

A prototype is a preliminary model of something. It is an early sample that is used to test a concept or process, or to act as a thing to be replicated or learned from. The main goal of a prototype is to reduce the risk involved in creating new products and services by allowing errors and problems to be identified and solved before too much time and money has been spent on the idea.

While a proof-of-concept is an early version of a product that focuses on testing one aspect of the product, a prototype, on the other hand, is a more complex and complete version of the product that tests several aspects. By creating a prototype, you can test how easy it is to use, as well as how useful it may be for your intended audience.

MLP VS. MVP

The concept of MVP (minimum viable product) or MLP (minimum loveable product) is used to identify the features

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that are most integral to a product and are likely to generate traction.

An MVP is just the bare minimum of any product. It can't offer a complete experience, but it gets you started with features that make the product functional. An MLP is a more advanced version of an MVP, with additional features and consideration for what the final product should offer in totality.

The goal of an MVP is to get your product, service, or idea out in front of customers as quickly and cheaply as possible. This allows you to quickly learn things like how customers and the market will react, what features could use improvement or need more attention, and just how viable your business is.

THE MINIMUM VIABLE PRODUCT AND LEAN STARTUP PHILOSOPHY

The minimum viable product concept is based on the lean startup methodology, which applies to both products and businesses as a whole. The lean startup concept is a business innovation strategy in which new products are developed and launched quickly with minimal resources to test if a business model or product works early on, rather than spending time developing an elaborate plan that might turn out to be unworkable.

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MINIMUM VIABLE PRODUCT VS MINIMUM MARKETABLE PRODUCT

Although similar, a minimum viable product is not the same as a minimum marketable product. An MVP is basically one that allows an entrepreneur to test his or her product and see what users respond well to. A minimal marketable product is complete with the most basic features users require from the product and ready to sell, but can still be improved upon if needed.

MINIMUM VIABLE PRODUCT VS PROOF OF CONCEPT

- While the idea behind proof of concept is similar to that of an MVP, there are some key differences. For example, an MVP showcases the viability of a product or service to potential customers (usually for free or for a small amount of cash), whereas proof of concept only assesses the feasibility and technical aspects of your business idea.

- An MVP can be a crude prototype of an idea, but the product must be functional and just basic enough to spur interest in what comes next. However, a proof of concept is just a stark concept, with no design or in any shape ready to be used by customers.

  The development of a minimum viable product is a great idea for startups. It allows you to see whether customers like your ideas or not, before you spend all your money on development and marketing. Plus, an

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MVP can help convince investors that your product fills a need in the market.

POCs are also great for investors, as they prove to them that your company has some solid ideas behind it.

MINIMUM AWESOME PRODUCT (MAP) VS MVP

While an MVP has an initial design and UX upon first development, an MAP has to do with iterative improvement upon this design or user experience streamlining/improvement.

MINIMUM MARKETABLE FEATURE (MMF)

A minimum marketable feature is the smallest feature that provides real value to customers that can be built into a product in order to test its market fit. It must answer a real need and solve a problem they have. To be marketable, the feature must be of high quality and usability.

MINIMUM VIABLE BRAND (MVB)

An MVB is a compact, stripped-down version of a brand that still retains enough value to be published. It has enough benefits and value that people will want to use it, and it's flexible enough to improve based on user feedback.

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MINIMUM VIABLE CO-FOUNDER

When starting a company, it can be difficult to find someone to co-found the business with you. In order to find a minimum viable co-founder, certain characteristics should be considered such as reliability, commitment, likability, productivity, and reasonable, rational, and realistic views.

MINIMUM VIABLE TEAM

The minimum viable team is the smallest group of people you need to get your job done. The optimal size of an MVT depends on the type of project and what resources are available, but one common size for an MVT is three to five people.

DIFFERENCE BETWEEN MVP (MINIMUM VIABLE PRODUCT), WORKING PROTOTYPE, AND BETA VERSION

The differences between an MVP, a working prototype, and a beta version border on their purposes. While an MVP is built to validate market (check for available target audience) and assumptions, a working prototype tries to validate technology to determine whether building the product is possible, on the other hand, a beta version focuses on validating solutions and scalability. Here is an explanation of their difference:

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- **MVP**
  The main goal of an MVP is to gather feedback on whether your product or service is useful. MVPs can be anything, including a working software prototype, a landing page, or a service you perform yourself;

- **Working Prototype**
  Prototypes can also be minimum viable products, but it's common for companies to begin with a working prototype, since the technology involved rather than the target market could be the biggest problem;

- **Beta Version**
  When you have a market for your product and a working prototype, you will want to test whether the product will meet the needs of that market. To help make certain you have chosen something that people want, it is best to survey your target audience through beta versions before you invest in mass production.

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COMMON PITFALLS

The term MVP is usually misunderstood, most times, teams don’t fully grasp its meaning, thinking it's all about the minimum functionality they can deliver. This often results in them leaving out features that will aid in market viability assessment.

A product development team may unwittingly confuse a Minimum Viable Product (MVP) — intended for feedback gathering — with a Minimum Marketable Feature (MMF) or Minimum Marketable Product (MMP), intended for revenue generation. It is not harmful to conflate the two, except the team spends too much time creating features with which customers may not be satisfied.

Teams often choose to deliver only the bare minimum of an MVP, while ignoring potentially valuable features. This approach can lead to products that are difficult for customers to use and don't provide enough value for money. These teams also often ignore user feedback, forgetting that the main purpose of an MVP is to gather user feedback and improve their product.

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KEY CHARACTERISTICS OF A MINIMUM VIABLE PRODUCT

- It provides room for gauging user reception and feedback gathering for future iterative improvements — a minimum viable product is a great way to get started; it allows you to create the core features and then iterate on those to create something that many people will find helpful.
- It has enough inherent value that even at release, people are willing to buy or use it. An MVP should give early adopters a glimpse of what the final product can become.

  When creating an MVP, consider what value the product will provide for its target market, and what problems it might be able to solve for them.
- Startups typically have less working capital, which means they have to be creative in how they spend their money. It is important to build the minimum viable product (MVP) quickly and inexpensively so that you can get feedback from users and make changes before spending significant time or money building it.
- The MVP shouldn't create too much negative impact when it is released into the market to gauge user reception. This negative impact can come in the form

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of poor user reception, however, improvements can be made to the product since its purpose is to garner user feedback and to test if certain theories hold in the market it was built for.

The negative impact from the MVP can also be in the form of negative user perception of the business/brand as a whole.

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WHAT IS NOT A MINIMUM VIABLE PRODUCT

A Minimum Viable Product, or MVP, is a product with just enough features to satisfy early customers and provide feedback for future development. Anything that is meant to be sold at scale is not an MVP. Non-MVP also includes products such as:

A PRODUCT THAT DOES NOT REMAIN TRUE TO ITS ASSUMPTIONS

When building a Minimum Viable Product (MVP), most of the time, people do not remember why they are doing this. The main reason for building a Minimum Viable Product (MVP) is to get early validation of the idea so that you can ensure that your assumptions are correct. Product developers while acting contrary to this often believe their assumptions are correct and use MVPs as a testing ground for certain product features.

A PRODUCT THAT IS NOT DEVELOPED ITERATIVELY

The Minimum Viable Product (MVP) approach should be an iterative one. This means that you build upon a solid

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foundation in each iteration, adding more value to your product with each release. The idea is to start with a small but viable product and keep adding features as you go along.

NON-MINIMUM MVP

Product managers don't often think about the need to keep an MVP lean and simple. Keeping it simple helps avoid having a product grow too large, or too early in its lifecycle, which can cause problems down the road. Having an MVP that is too large with an already established core functionality makes changing the product difficult if user reception is poor.

A POOR QUALITY MVP

Although it is best to keep an MVP lean and simple, having a poor quality MVP is also bad for product development, since an MVP is strictly about releasing into the market the most minimum "viable" product.

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HOW MVP WORKS

Working with the Minimum Viable Product (MVP) means that your project will be easier and faster to create, as you'll be able to uncover what works and what doesn't much earlier in the process. MVPs are all about validating assumptions, collecting learnings, and understanding if a business idea has potential or not. In essence, an MVP should work like the image below and should only have one or two features, testing one hypothesis/market assumption to test its market potential.

In its simplest form, the product may be a single box or a single feature. An increasing number of features will be added over time. However, none of the features will be implemented if they fail to pass validation testing.

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TYPES OF MINIMUM VIABLE PRODUCT

The minimum viable product (MVP) is a learning tool intended to help companies develop products through rapid experimentation. An MVP is so-called because it provides the bare minimum level of features necessary to deliver core functionality, hence allowing startups to launch early and learn from customers' reactions. To see how an MVP can be applied, let's examine some types of MVPs:

LOW-FIDELITY MVP TYPES

Customer problems, in and of themselves, are not always an indication that customers are willing to pay for solutions. Therefore, just identifying customer needs should be the main criteria for determining if your product idea is worth developing. Low-fidelity MVPs help identify the customers that can be served and the nature of the problem more precisely.

The Fake Door
Another name for this is the “audience building MVP,” or an “MVP before the MVP.” It allows product creators to gauge interest in a theoretical feature, without having to build that feature or product.

Think about a scenario in which you want to test out a Premium subscription plan for your service that provides additional features. You make a landing page with all the

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information and a call-to-action button that does not lead to a subscription page or checkout, but to a message that says this functionality is “under construction.” By collecting emails from interested users, you can notify them when it becomes ready. Thus determining the willingness of customers to pay for that feature/solution.

Landing page MVP
This is a variant of “The Fake Door” approach. Nevertheless, you do not need to pretend that a product already exists before showing a "coming soon" message. The concept is simple, you provide visitors to your site with a variety of options to choose from and the benefits of such options.

The benefit of this is that you can connect with your target audience and gather feedback about what users like and dislike about products like yours before it's made. This type of MVP is great for startups, since starting a new business can be tough. Without an audience or product, it's almost impossible to get feedback from users. You can solve this problem by using landing page MVPs.

While you can create an MVP with a landing page that helps generate interest in your product, a landing page MVP might not convert visitors into customers. Additionally, if people leave the page without taking action, it's hard to tell what turned them away.

Email MVP
If you already have customers, building an email newsletter is a simple and effective means of communicating with them. You can start by manually creating some newsletters to see if your audience responds favorably, and then add product features after you've seen that it's worth the time.

If you notice that most of your recipients are opening the email but not clicking on the call-to-action button, you will

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then know for a fact that people aren't interested in your offer.

Marketing Campaign MVP

To research your target audience, you can try using some of the more traditional promotional methods available now. You can make posts on social networks, find potential influencers in your field, and find out if customers are interested in your product idea. Keeping up on social media trends and connecting with people who might be interested in what you're offering is also a great way to build interest in your concept.

HIGH-FIDELITY MVP TYPES

When you develop a low-fidelity MVP, you do not have to invest a lot of money in developing software or infrastructure. However, some uncertainty remains. You cannot get feedback from early adopters. Once you develop a high-fidelity MVP, you can detect more user wants and needs and make appropriate changes to your product.

Single-Feature MVP

This is a product, usually software, that contains only the core feature or functionality of your future product. You can test your idea by creating a single-feature MVP and releasing it to see how users will react to it.

Since creating a feature-rich MVP is time-consuming and expensive, creating a single-feature MVP can be an excellent way to gain a foothold in a market because it addresses one specific need of your customers. If created well and combined with good marketing, it can help you build a positive reputation for your product.

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Pre-order MVP
This is usually a situation where future product functionalities and values are explained to consumers, who help fund the final development of the product in exchange for rewards. This method is a great way to get funding if you have an exciting product idea that you feel consumers would want.

A pre-order MVP allows startups to raise funds by prepaying for the product. However, looking through the eyes of a customer, there are certain risks involved in this approach. Firstly, customers are investing in an unfinished product and might feel uneasy with the idea of buying a non-existent product. Secondly, they have to trust their money with a new startup, even though prepaying for a product is usually only deemed safe when buying from already existing businesses.

Concierge MVP
It is a product that simulates many different functions, and yet it relies on a human to carry out its primary functions. Ultimately, you need to be aware of what the user wants and needs, and help them as needed.

Concierge MVPs involve manually helping your users accomplish their goals and seeing whether they need what you're offering or not. You don't even have to build a product to run an effective concierge MVP.

For instance, Manuel Rosso, CEO of Food on the Table, at the beginning of his company provided shoppers with a $10/month in-person service that generates shopping lists tailored to individual needs. He now has an app that automates his previous in-person services.

Wizard of Oz MVP
This MVP gives the appearance of being a fully functional solution, but it masks the true inner workings of your product. The name was coined from the movie “The Wizard of Oz”

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where an old man controls everything happening outside with a lever, while others thought an entirely different thing was the case.

A perfect example is Aardvark, a question and answer service which referred questions to experts, and was manually operated early on. Aardvark staff would just post questions and responses back and forth between people (askers and experts). Later, the product was built to include algorithms that automated the processes.

Piecemeal MV

This is an inexpensive way of delivering products to customers. The idea here is to use existing tools and solutions so that you don't have to develop everything from scratch. You can, for instance, offer products from other marketplaces in your catalog and deliver orders using third-party services. If you've got a ready-made marketplace software in place, there's no need to start over again with your own.

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COULD YOUR STARTUP BE USING AN MVP?

When you are building a product, it's a good idea for startups to focus on core features that solve your users' problems and not on every bell and whistle you can think of. That way, you'll save time, money, and effort and get valuable feedback on what your customers want from your product.

When it comes to startups, statistics show that 42 percent of them fail. According to these figures, the absence of market need is a reason why so many startups fail. If you want your startup to succeed, it's best to focus on getting feedback before you go any further.

When starting a business, the most important step is to build a minimum viable product (MVP). An MVP can save you money and avoid failure by allowing you to test your assumptions and find out what works best. There are two ways that you can go after building an MVP. You can pivot, or iterate on your business model as needed, or you can give up on your idea, at least for the time being, so that you don't waste any more time and money.

Starting with an MVP allows a startup to avoid some of the top reasons why startups fail, since you can discover if there is a market need for your product while keeping costs low and improving on your product after proving the availability of the target market.

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WHAT TYPE OF MVP IS BEST FOR YOU?

The point of building an MVP is to learn. This means you can learn about potential customers and what products they like; you can also learn about your business and its strengths and weaknesses. However, to develop an MVP, you need to know exactly what you want to learn. And whether the chosen approach will help you achieve your goals.

When you have a basic or a vague understanding of the market you want to enter, you need to conduct market research to better understand your venture, that's where the concierge comes in. This is because this type of MVP allows you to get one-on-one feedback from customers, and to understand their needs and possible ways of helping them fulfill those needs.

If, however, you know much about the market, but don't know if your audience will be interested in your idea for solving the market needs, you can use the landing page MVP or the pre-order MVP.

When your aim for an MVP is to know what people will think of your product when using it, you can go The Wizard of OZ or Single-Feature MVP route.

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THE PURPOSE OF A MINIMUM VIABLE PRODUCT

Eric Ries, the entrepreneurial guru who co-founded IMVU and led much of its growth to success, is an advocate for developing minimum viable products.

His description of the purpose of an MVP when exemplified goes like this: a company will create an MVP when it wants to test with little effort a potential product or service with consumers to gather data and insights that help the company determine whether a more comprehensive project should be launched.

TO ENTER THE MARKET WITH A SMALL BUDGET

MVP is popular among new entrants to the market. It's common for companies to launch a new product with a minimal budget, to test the viability of the product in different situations. If the product fails, the company can rectify its problems and errors afterward without incurring significant losses.

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TO FIND THE RIGHT AUDIENCE

When creating a business plan, one of your primary goals is to find the right audience. The MVP concept can help you reach your target audience by drawing on knowledge and time.

TO CREATE A BALANCE BETWEEN COMPANY OFFERINGS AND CUSTOMER NEEDS

For company owners, entrepreneurs, and creators, building something nobody wants is a nightmare. That's why they can't rest until they've built a viable product. A viable product helps them figure out what the customers want and encourages them to strike a fine balance between offering and need. They improve the product or introduce something entirely different if it will satisfy the customer's needs.

TO MINIMIZE ERRORS

Mobile app and web app developers use minimum viable product ideas to test the product hypothesis at the early stage of development. This helps eliminate or reduce errors, minimizes risks, and speeds up software product development.

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TO COLLECT THE MAXIMUM QUALITY FEEDBACK

Getting feedback is vital for any business, especially new businesses. It can be hard to get positive feedback, but sometimes it can be even harder to get negative feedback. Because you want to cater to a specific niche of consumers, you need to create a minimum viable product (MVP) to help target that niche and collect quality feedback from these people.

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WHAT IS THE MVP DEVELOPMENT PROCESS?

MVPs are the bare-bones versions of products that are developed in the early stages of development. MVPs typically contain the core features and basic functionalities, so you can measure the response of your target market. Then, after a series of iterations with feedback from early adopters, you can build the actual product with the full set of features. Rather than building layers one at a time, it involves building a slice over the whole development process.

MVP Development plays an important role in product development and design. A well-designed and developed MVP can help a business test its product, develop it, and deliver the final product.

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MVP PRODUCT DEVELOPMENT BENEFITS

- **Market Validation:** An MVP represents a stripped-down version of your product. It's designed to test key business theories and gather feedback from customers. By creating an MVP, you can narrow your focus and determine exactly what value you will be providing to your potential customers.

  If you have a firm grasp of what your customers truly want, your product launch will be more efficient. When you build in only the basic features for the first version of your product, you can test your ideas and gather valuable customer feedback before spending time and money on additional features.

- **Feedback & Iterative Development:** MVP is a development approach that facilitates an inexpensive way to test your business idea. Since users make judgments about software products incredibly quickly, if they don't like how something works, they won't hesitate to uninstall the app or delete the software product.

  It can help you avoid burdening your customers with unnecessary functionality and enable you to target the core functionality they are most interested in.

  Focusing on the bare essentials, first, allows you to efficiently test your business idea and make

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improvements based on customer feedback.

You can launch a product with a minimum viable product (MVP) to test it on real customers. This gives you early indications of what might cause problems, what features are most popular, and info on the general user experience.

When developing a new product, it's not enough to have a lot of downloads — you also have to keep users engaged. An MVP (minimum viable product) allows you to test the user experience on early adopters. You can make changes and scale up your product based on the feedback you get from them.

- **Testing Product Profit Generation Models:** If you want to make money with your product, you'll have to experiment with multiple strategies. An initial plan might look good on paper, but you still need to try it out before deciding whether it works for you or not. That's where MVPs come in.

  If, for example, you are developing an application monetization strategy for in-app purchases, you can use a minimum viable product to test its effectiveness and see how users feel about it. This will give you an idea of whether this solution is effective or not.

- **Helps in Attracting Investors:** Investors and stakeholders are vital for almost any business, and the easiest way to capture their attention is to develop a minimum viable product. It usually takes little time or money to create an MVP, but it is the quickest way to find out if consumers will find your product useful or not.

  Investors are looking for opportunities that are likely to be successful, and that's understandable. MVPs let you

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show them what you're working on; if your MVP has already proven itself successful with users, it's more likely that your project will gain their support.

- **Cost-Efficient:** It is worth mentioning again that the low cost of an MVP is one of its major advantages. As a rule, full-scale product development is much more expensive than that of a minimum viable product, since they include more features, take up more time, and thus burn through more resources.

  An MVP that gradually becomes a full product is usually more cost-effective in the long run than an approach that goes all-in. When companies add many excessive features just to be safe, they often end up paying more for those features than if they had gone for an MVP in the first place and found out what users will prefer.

MORE FOCUS ON BUILDING THE CORE

Rather than coming up with a product that has every bell and whistle feature imaginable, it's better to put out a stripped-down version first. By doing so, you can establish whether your core product concept is the right fit for your target market.

METEORIC (SPEEDY) PRODUCT DEVELOPMENT

Speedy means designing and releasing an application as soon as possible, making improvements quickly as feedback

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is gathered, and changing direction based on what is learned.

MARKET VALIDATION

MVP development is aimed at testing and determining what works and what doesn't work in the market. The goal is to understand what the market demands and to put out a product that will satisfy existing customers and attract new ones. This eliminates the chances of developing products no customer wants.

MINIMIZING THE PRODUCT DEVELOPMENT COST

When your team builds only the key features of an app upfront, cases of poor user reception, schedule delays, and product budget overruns will be reduced. This way you can spend more time getting feedback from actual customers rather than spending all of your time and money on features nobody needs.

MORE FEEDBACK = IMPROVED PRODUCT

Getting feedback from your customers at the early development stage of a product helps shape the experience they have with that product and will foster iterative improvements.

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THE NEED TO BUILD AN MVP

- **Clear Focus:** The MVP approach enables you to focus on the specific value your product can offer the market. It will be easier for you to identify your target customer and the problem they've been experiencing (i.e., the need that your product will be solving). This approach will also help you to choose what functionality will be implemented first in your product – and thus save you money;

- **You Get Feedback On What Can Be Improved:** Building an MVP gets you quality feedback from your target market on what features should be improved or added to better handle their needs. Applying improvements recommended by the feedback you've gathered makes your product a better market fit and sets it up for success;

- **Cost Efficiency:** Because an MVP provides only a very basic set of features, developers will be able to create it more quickly than when creating a full-fledged product. That means you'll spend less money developing your product. If you can identify your first customers with an MVP and then raise funds during its operating period, you'll be able to develop your product with earned profit-making future developments cheaper;

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- **Your MVP Results in a Total Failure:** Sometimes, an MVP will help you to refine and adjust your idea. But sometimes all of your hard work doesn't work out. Launching an MVP is much better than spending time and money on a complete product that fails in the market. By keeping your Minimum Viable Product cheaper and simpler, you can use those saved resources to launch another idea.

STATS EMPHASIZING THE NEED TO BUILD AN MVP

Considering that 29% of startups fail due to lack of capital, you should be cautious about the amount of money you put upfront into your business, while growth rates for startups scaling properly are 20 times higher than those scaling prematurely.

These statistics show that starting a new product development through an MVP is a sure way to keep costs low while still building products customers will love. This will ultimately allow your business to scale properly and according to customer demands.

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HOW TO BUILD AN MVP: A SIMPLE GUIDE

The minimum viable product development process uses a top-down and iterative approach with test-driven milestones. Steps in this process include identifying the problem, defining the target audience, creating the solution, testing the solution via early adopters, making improvements to the solution, and evaluating customers' reactions.

Building a minimum viable product can be a complex process. The acronym S.I.M.P.L.E. can help you remember the key steps to creating a successful MVP.

START WITH MARKET RESEARCH

A good idea may have the potential to bring you profits and make your business grow. But a lot of times, you will find out that your idea is not what the customers want. To determine if your idea is worth pursuing, it's important to run some market research and surveys with potential customers so that you can find out more about what they want.

IDEATE ON VALUE ADDITION

The potential market for a product, combined with the relationship your product has with other products, is likely much more important than the product itself in determining whether the product will become successful. Your product will

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not be successful if you cannot answer these questions:

1. Why is your idea valuable to its target audience?
2. What are the benefits your idea can provide?
3. Why should they buy your idea?

MAP OUT USER FLOW

When you rush to develop the Minimum Viable Product (MVP) without clearly outlining the design and user flow, you might end up with a product that no one wants to use. When designing your product's user flow, keep in mind who your target audience is so that it is easy for them to use.

PRIORITIZE MVP FEATURES

A reliable MVP development company will help you determine the essential features for a successful launch. The MoSCoW prioritization method is a good way to prioritize the features that you want to be included in your MVP.

- **M:** Must-have features
- **S:** Should have features
- **C:** Could have features
- **W:** Won't need features

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LAUNCH MVP

When you have identified market needs and selected a few features based on MoSCoW, start building your MVP. While building an MVP, remember that although it is not a final product, it should be built with the highest degree of quality to satisfy the customer as much as possible.

EXERCISE 'B.M.L.' — BUILD, MEASURE, LEARN

The Build-Measure-Learn (B.M.L.) loop is one of the most important steps in building an MVP. It deals with measuring the acceptance of your MVP through feedback, and also allows you to assess whether it needs to be improved or not. Based on customer feedback, you can continually iterate your product so that it improves over time.

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MVP METRICS

BUSINESS VS. USER METRICS

The measurement is divided into two aspects:

- **Business:** Analyzing business-critical metrics
- **Customer:** Analyzing the user behavioral metrics

Business-critical metrics are statistics used to evaluate a company's performance and product. These metrics like sales revenue, gross margin, net profit margin, and monthly recurring revenue will tell you if your business idea is profitable.

User behavioral metrics capture how users interact with the MVP and the final product. These metrics help assess which features are central to the app's success. They can be measured by analyzing churn rate, bounce rate, page views, load times, retention, and conversion rates.

VANITY METRICS VS ACTIONABLE METRICS

Vanity Metrics
While it's important to have a high number of Twitter followers and Facebook fans, these metrics do not necessarily reflect whether your product is viable or not. You can have thousands of followers on Twitter and never make a sale. The

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number of Twitter followers, Facebook fans, and blog subscribers you have doesn't tell you anything about the viability of your product, but rather how well you can publicize/market it.

Actionable Metrics

Actionable metrics are the most effective way to measure the viability of your idea. They can be tough to look at, but you need that kind of brutal honesty if you're going to make good decisions. These metrics include conversion rate, return on marketing investment, customer lifetime value, customer acquisition costs, etc.

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KEY MVP DEVELOPMENT MISTAKES

CHOOSING THE WRONG PROBLEM TO SOLVE

When beginning to develop a minimum viable product, it is important to consider the customer needs on which it will be built. If your product is not able to solve a problem for your customer base, then efficiency is not important.

SKIPPING THE PROTOTYPING PHASE

Prototypes help clarify the relationship between an idea and a complete product.

In the process of product development, the idea for a product must be transformed into a full-fledged product or service. The evolution from idea to prototype is essential to this transformation.

It is easy to overlook details when you are in the early stages of designing a product, and prototyping can help you avoid these oversights.

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TARGETING THE WRONG SET OF PERSONA

It's not worth getting feedback from friends and family if they're not the target audience for your prototype. Instead, find people who can give you honest feedback in your target market.

INAPPROPRIATE DEVELOPMENT METHOD

Of the startups that do succeed, about 90% of them fail. Failing to choose the appropriate MVP development methodology — Agile, Waterfall, or DevOps — is one of the main reasons for this failure.

Compared to Waterfall (Traditional Method), Agile product development offers speed to market, increased efficiency, and improved results. Agile offers an incremental approach that is flexible and focused on iterative development. Confusion between Qualitative and Quantitative Feedback There are two ways to collect data from the right audience: quantitative and qualitative feedback. Quantitative feedback is useful for measuring things like the number of clicks and how long people spend on a site. Qualitative feedback, on the other hand, can give a more accurate idea of how people feel about something by asking them to explain it in their own words.

Both approaches are equally important, so you can't rely on one type of feedback and ignore the other.

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TIPS TO TARGET THE RIGHT MARKET WHILE BUILDING AN MVP

1. ANALYZE THE COMPETITION

When you're launching a startup, you have to do a lot of work to understand the market and your competitors. You have to make sure that whatever idea you have fills an existing and unmet need. Even if your product is unique, it will still be competing with other products in the same industry.

As a result, they should research the industry and figure out where their product fits in. They should find out what their competitors are doing and how they are targeting their audience. The startup can do this by assessing the strengths and weaknesses of the competitors. They can also figure out if there is a group that the competitors have overlooked and try to reach that audience.

2. GEOGRAPHICALLY SEGMENT THE CUSTOMER BASE

If a startup has identified the correct customer base for its MVP, it will want to think about geographic segmentation. By

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doing so, the company will be able to familiarize itself with the location-based attributes that define its ideal target market. By analyzing the location of its target market, the startup can get a better sense of what that market is interested in and how best to appeal to them while building an MVP.

By individually targeting people in different areas of the country, startups can develop more efficient products and marketing campaigns. Startups that are interested in this approach must first find ways to identify their target customer's geographic location. If this is done, the startup can then develop its MVP by answering these important questions:



3. FIND THE MOTIVATION BEHIND A PURCHASE

Once you've identified your audience, it's important to understand what they want and why they want it. By understanding their needs, you can create a product that speaks to them in a way that resonates, which helps to move the business forward. One of the best ways to gather this

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information is to conduct customer surveys, which can be conducted in different ways based on the budget available.

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TOOLS TO BUILD MVP

- **Airtable:** Airtable has numerous features, including a relational database design and a spreadsheet UI, which makes it easy for users to quickly input and interact with data. The platform is also highly extensible through the use of blocks; small plugins that can be deployed onto an Airtable database to add functionality. You can integrate Airtable with Stripe, a PayPal alternative, to accept payments online, which you can use to manage lists of customers and their orders in your Airtable database;

- **WebFlow:** WebFlow is an easy-to-use website builder that makes it simple for MVP developers to create spectacular websites without coding. WebFlow is a WYSIWYG host where you can create landing pages, blog pages, and other prominent website pages. It helps improve the overall user experience by saving time on design. The code is properly written, and the designs are excellent. WebFlow also has a great library of helpful articles and videos that can guide you through your website building project;

- **Figma:** Figma is a cloud-based, collaborative design tool that allows you to create prototypes, wireframes, and mockups, replacing the need for Adobe Photoshop or Sketch. Figma is a B2B product that allows designers to create and share design concepts with developers. Figma integrates with most code editors and can be configured for integration with Slack, Confluence, JIRA, and other productivity

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products;

- **Google Docs:** Google Docs is a cloud-based, collaboration platform that allows users to create, store, and edit documents and spreadsheets. It includes charting capabilities, templates, edit suggestions and commenting. It's ideal for small to large companies who want to optimize the way their teams share ideas and communicate;

- **Google Forms:** Google Forms is a web-based software that lets users create surveys, quizzes, and more. It's part of Google's web-based suite of apps, including Google Docs, Google Sheets, and many more. It's a great way to get people to respond when you need answers fast;

- **Framer:** Framer is a tool for quickly creating interactive or animated prototypes of your product. It's helpful for product designers to showcase a product without needing to write any code.

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MVP IMPLEMENTATION STEPS

1. Define your product
If you have an idea for a product, the first thing to do is to figure out what problem your product will solve;

2. Prepare product requirements
Before you begin to design your product, list the features it will have. This will help you to understand your product better;

3. Identify Priority Product Requirements (PPR)
The development of the Minimum Viable Product (MVP) is a challenging phase in strategy. The task of identifying which features are essential for the MVP is crucial and can be confusing. Those features with the highest priority make up the Priority Product Requirements (PPR);

4. Find PPR dependency with other requirements
When you're developing a product, it's helpful to identify high-priority features that are dependent on other features so that development can be streamlined, while also making future improvements can be made easily;

5. Launch the product
Make sure the product is launched with the features that matter most;

6. Get Feedback and implement changes
When you launch a new product, make sure to get feedback

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from your customers. Change the product as needed to meet their needs and wants. This is a process that you can use with every MVP unless there is no market for the product.

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WHY YOU SHOULD TEST AN MVP

When you plan to test an MVP, you have two options for setting up the process: You can check your product's quality before sending it to market, or you can let potential customers try your work before forming any conclusions about your business idea. Making sure your product is good and asking for feedback are not opposites; they're complementary, so you should perform both.

The first product testing begins as a process during the development stage. The team builds prototypes, which are tested to choose the most suitable option. A prototype is a preliminary version of the product, which is usually created with rough materials and serves to test different possibilities in the design. Among these variants, there are a few that meet the parameters of the target audience based on research or a team selects one which they think meets potential customers' needs best.

To ensure your app is ready for the market, it must be tested by a quality assurance team. You need to ensure that it does not contain glitches and works as intended. A minimum viable product must undergo beta testing before being released to the public. Testing, which simulates real-world conditions, can help you identify bugs before a wider release.

After you've launched your product, the next step is to test it with as many customers as possible. The goal is to get feedback about the product and decide if your initial idea was

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successful or not. After gathering this information, you can choose to continue along the same path or change your concept.

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HOW TO VALIDATE YOUR MVP PRODUCT?

An MVP helps you test-drive your product idea before you invest time and money in a fully functional product. You engage the target audience and capture feedback, which lets you improve the offering. To validate, you must test the product to establish whether it meets users' needs. It's not enough to just build an MVP; you must have an effective process for putting your MVP through its paces and making sure it delivers on key quality standards.

CROWDFUNDING

This is a great way to test whether your product is viable in the market and to raise money. Websites like IndieGoGo or Kickstarter let you do that by offering platforms where you can introduce your Minimum Viable Product and raise capital that can help you get your business off the ground. Along with this, you get a market valuation for your idea.

PRE-ORDER PAGES

You can pre-sell your product to your potential customer base by getting them involved in the early stages of product design. If people like what they see, they can put their money down on the table and validate an MVP before you spend time and money developing a product that your customers might not even want.

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CUSTOMER INTERVIEWS

Customer interviews are a great way to test whether your MVP is viable — ask your target customers what they think about the product (feedback) and whether there are any improvements or new features that would make it better.

PIECEMEAL MVPS

This approach presents an excellent way to validate your MVP business by spending little or no money on a product and using existing platforms, services, and tools to introduce it to the target audience.

LANDING PAGES

Creating a landing page to explain the features of your product is a great way to test your MVP. Tracking visitors' actions and behavior can tell you whether they're interested in what you're offering. Analyzing data about visitors with tools like Hotjar and Google Analytics will give you valuable insight.

EXPLAINER VIDEOS

Having a story-driven video that illustrates how your product or service solves a problem can help you increase your sign-up rates.

AD CAMPAIGNS

By running ad campaigns before your product is launched, you can generate user engagement and collect data about

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how many people are clicking on your ads and which ad copy converts best.

SOCIAL MEDIA SURVEYS

After you've segmented your audience, you can use the results of social media surveys to get a quick and better idea of how prospective customers feel about your product.

A/B TESTING

This is a great way to see which version of a newsletter, email campaign, landing page, app, or blog works best. You can use tools like HubSpot and Google Analytics to gather data about your customers' behavior and insights that can help you make improvements over time.

NEW SIGNUPS

Getting people to sign up for your product comes from reaching out to the right audience with a quality MVP. Your product validation increases as more people sign up for it.

HOW TO CONDUCT AN EFFECTIVE USER INTERVIEW FOR YOUR MVP

Conducting an effective user interview has several facets that need to be addressed before, during, and after the interview:

Before the Interview:

Set an Interview Goal
Before starting an interview, you need to set your goals. If the

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goal is too general and broad, it's unlikely to succeed. You want to focus your questions on one or several needs. The reasons why you want to interview and what you want to gain are very helpful in deciding what your specific goals should be. Good goals focus on one specific aspect of the user experience and help the team reach a consensus about what to tackle next. Here are some examples of useful interview goals:

A. To understand why users abandon their online shopping carts;

B. To discover why users abandon your product after a few days or months of usage.

Find Users to Interview

Finding respondents to interview is a two-step process. First, you need to identify the users who will best suit your purposes. For example, to get insights into mobile shopping behavior, you might choose people who shop mainly on their mobile phones. Also, it’s important to keep track of the characteristics of your interviewees so that you can use them to select your participants later on in the project. You can find interviewees by going out on the street, paying people to interview them, or family and friends if your products are in the b2C category.

Design Questions and an interview workflow

- **Greetings:** Use small talk to get the interviewees to relax and open up. You need to make them feel comfortable;
- **Problem Qualification:** Try to understand your users' pain points and their expectations for their ideal solution;
- **Describe your solution compellingly:** Share what

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you've learned from your work in the industry, how you came to create your solution, and what makes it different from other options;

- **Solution exploration and demo:** Show your MVP to your users and then evaluate how it matches up with what users expect to get out of it and the value they're hoping to find;

- **Closing:** Make efforts to schedule a meeting with the prospect to continue the relationship.

Perform a mock test interview
Next, you should conduct a mock interview to get a better idea of how your prospective employer will respond to your questions. Try out different types of questions and refine the script until you feel comfortable with it. Avoid relying too much on scripted questions, which can be uncomfortable for interviewees and may lead to stereotyped answers. To achieve optimal results, every question should be tailored to the context and the respondent.

During the Interview

Build rapport with interviewees
Creating rapport with respondents is an important part of an in-person interview. The interviewer should be friendly and relaxed, and take the lead in breaking the ice. Keeping the participants comfortable will help them feel more confident, which will make for better interviews.

Clarify problem qualification
The discussion should aim to gain a clear understanding of the problem. The interviewer has to make sure that everyone understands what the problem is and who has it. Everyone must agree on one problem so that you can show them a solution.

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Tell a compelling story
When you've established that the other party understands your problem, it's time to present a solution. If you have a presentation or visual aid to help explain your pitch, this is a good place to use it.

Explain who you are and what makes you different from the competition. Tell them why you're passionate about solving their problem and how they'll benefit from working with you. Be honest in your presentation — business buyers and influencers want to hear from humans, not machines!

Explore solution and demo
Before you pitch your MVP, try to learn more about what customers want. Ask them to describe their pain points, and listen carefully to the words they use. If a feature has not yet been implemented, consider how you can incorporate this information into your product.

After allowing them to play with your MVP for a few minutes, ask for feedback about what they think it does. This can help you learn what features are missing or what you might need to improve upon.

Close the Interview
When you reach the last question in the interview, give your respondents a sense of closure. You can do this by telling them that you appreciate their time and feedback. Let them know they can ask questions about your product if they want to, and then let them know how much you appreciate their willingness to help out with additional sessions if they're willing. If you promised an incentive for taking the interview, now is a good time to offer it to them.

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After the Interview

Structure the information

Now, you'll probably have a lot of data, including recordings of the interview and notes you took while talking to the person. From your observations, you can develop insights into what new products or features may interest people, how they might use those products or features in their daily lives, and how you could design or develop those features in ways that better meet their needs.

Conduct a retrospective

Once you've completed your interviews and developed your MVP, take a step back and assess what you've learned. Revise your screening criteria to see how this new information fits with it. Then, measure and analyze this new information to help improve your MVP into a full-fledged product. And finally, repeat this process with more interviews to make sure you continue making customer-centric changes as you develop your product.

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FEW MORE WAYS TO TEST AN MVP

EXPERIMENTAL MVP TESTING

Testing an idea with an experimental MVP can help you decide whether to pursue your idea further. It also helps you understand what your target audience thinks of your concept. When the results aren't positive, it's easy to forget about the concept. Either way, you haven't invested too much time or money in the experiment.

Airbnb's founders, Brian Chesky and Joe Gebbia, had the idea for an online marketplace connecting hosts with guests. They first tested their idea by renting out air mattresses in their apartment during a conference in San Francisco that all the city's hotels were booked for. The experiment was successful, and after that, they started the large-scale operation of Airbnb.

MANUAL-FIRST MVPS

A manual-first MVP is an efficient MVP testing technique in which we provide the product or service manually instead of using the software. The user gets what they want, believes that they're experiencing a complete product/service, and is satisfied with their experience.

The best thing about manual MVPs is that they help you run

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initial experiments and tests to see whether your MVP is working or not. You can measure your assumptions against the reality of your customers' lives and see whether your product is solving their needs or not.

CONCIERGE MVPS

Concierge MVPs are like manual-first MVPs, only instead of manually simulating a service or product, you provide a personalized service or product to customers. This approach is best used to test whether users like what you're offering or not, and see if they'd pay for that service or product.

Concierge MVP lets you quickly find out whether a product resonates with customers before you invest time and money in building a full version.

The online dress rental business Rent the Runway is a good example of a company using the Concierge MVP approach. In-person services were provided to college students before they made a purchase decision. Through this approach, the brand spread the word about itself and tested whether women were interested in renting dresses.

DIGITAL PROTOTYPING

Creating a digital prototype of your product is an excellent way to test it. Digital prototypes allow you to show potential customers how your product will function in real-life conditions, and they will help you get customer feedback before you start developing the actual product.

Although digital prototypes can vary from simple previews to more sophisticated, interactive mock-ups, tools like Figma, InvisionApp, and MarvelApp allow you to share and iterate on

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your ideas without having to build a full prototype every time.

PAPER PROTOTYPING

As an alternative to digital prototyping, paper prototypes are a great, excellent choice. Paper is easy to use, and you can get started quickly. You can create your MVP with just pen and paper, or if you want it to look more professional, you can use any drawing tool.

Paper prototyping can help you save money and time when creating your first version of a product. It allows for collaboration, as well as the exploration of many ideas without having to spend a lot of money.

SINGLE-FEATURE MVPS

When developing an MVP, it is often better to focus on one feature than to try and develop multiple features at once. Not only does this reduce the amount of time the product takes to develop, but it also allows you to pinpoint your target audience more easily. A single-feature MVP also makes MVP testing easier, since customers can focus on the main purpose of the app.

HALLWAY TESTING

The hallway test is another method for testing your MVP. For this, approach random people walking down the hallway and ask them to test your product.

Since they are not familiar with the product or its purpose, they will behave as real customers do when they try it for the first time. Take note of everything: their confusion, problems they face, and the amount of time they spend trying to

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complete an objective on it. This will enable you to evaluate whether your product is user-friendly and determine whether any interface elements or features need to be changed.

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HOW TO CONDUCT EFFECTIVE USABILITY TESTING

1. PLAN THOROUGHLY

Usability testing is a vital step in the user-centered design process. When planning usability testing, spend time early on deciding what features should be tested. To keep the results straightforward, define clear goals and limits for your test, such as one particular feature or problem that needs to be addressed.

Use specific questions to obtain useful results and compile them. This will make it faster for you to analyze and draw conclusions from your findings.

2. PREPARE A PROTOTYPE OR PRODUCT FOR TESTING

It's common to do usability testing in the early stages of development. This way, you have time to make changes before you must finalize anything. You can test a website with limited functionality or even a simple demo app.

It's helpful to build a prototype of your product that accurately

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represents what it will be like in the future. If you design your prototype carefully, your usability tests should be helpful. Be sure you understand what you want to test and how you want to test it before you start building your prototype.

3. FIND THE RIGHT USERS FOR TESTING

When you're recruiting users for your project, it's important to find people who match your target audience. For example, when recruiting users to test an online toy store, you'll want to make sure that the people you recruit are parents of young children, not teenagers.

Keep in mind that there can be more than one target audience for your project. If there is more than one set of users (e.g., marketers and developers), don't forget to recruit participants from each group. By recruiting only actual users of a product or system (as opposed to people involved in its design), you ensure that you'll get unbiased feedback.

4. CONDUCTING USABILITY TEST

To ensure that users aren't distracted, consider running your usability test in a conference room or a quiet space. If you can, arrange for the participant to use their familiar computer and browser. During your testing preparations, you should make sure that the user interface works for all different browsers and screen sizes.

Also, make sure to give plenty of time for each user to complete the test so that they don't feel rushed. To avoid biasing the user's opinion, ask them questions in a friendly but neutral tone for example, instead of asking what the best

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color for the dashboard is, ask how easy it is for them to find information on it. Make sure that you record your usability test so that you can go back and see where improvements are needed.

5. DOCUMENT THE TESTS WELL

Be sure to document all of your tests, including the setup of all equipment and what was involved in conducting each test. To be sure that you cover absolutely everything, fill out a template for documenting each test that you created beforehand. Refer back to this template as you conduct your tests; it will ensure that you record absolutely everything about how your tests were carried out and user responses.

6. ANALYZE AND REPEAT

Based on the test results and feedback, work with your designers and/or product managers to analyze the findings.

Keep an open mind. You are going to spot issues you didn't see coming, but that is where you'll get the most benefit from doing a user test. After spotting issues, you will now be able to make improvements on each iteration of your design. Planning and anticipating contingencies will enable you to easily set up and include usability tests into your development cycle.

To improve your product, continue to test and refine it. It has been proven that investing in usability testing can produce great results for a product or service. With this process, companies such as Amazon have launched successful products.

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EXAMPLES OF THE MINIMUM VIABLE PRODUCT

AIRBNB

To validate their idea for a business model that would allow for peer-to-peer rental housing online, the founders of Airbnb used their apartment as a way to connect guests with hosts. They created a simple website, published photos and other details about their property, and soon afterward they started getting paying guests.

FOURSQUARE

The Foursquare application launched in 2009 as a simple check-in tool, awarding virtual points to users who frequented specific locations. Over time, the Foursquare team added features such as personal recommendations and city guides, making the app more useful and appealing to its growing base of users.

FACEBOOK

In a cost-conscious effort, Facebook came up with an MVP that allowed college students to post messages on their virtual "boards," and it turned out to be enormously popular,

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with more than 5 million users by late 2005. This approach is to test out its business idea and develop into the top social media network available now.

TWITTER

In 2006, Twitter was released as a final product. The idea for Twitter grew out of a hackathon held by Odeo, a podcasting platform. When its employees started spending a lot of money from their pockets to post messages on the platform, they decided to release it as a final product instead of an internal messaging system.

ANGELLIST

Thinking of AngelList today, you might imagine a vibrant marketplace that connects startups to potential investors. But that's not the way it started! Initially, AngelList founders Babak Nivi and Naval Ravikant relied on their connections with other investors and entrepreneurs to pair them up. They relied on human ingenuity, not on algorithms or sophisticated tools.

While it started as a simple platform, it quickly developed into the startup community it is today.

BUFFER

When he started Buffer, the social media scheduling tool, founder Joel Gascoigne used an MVP (minimum viable product). It was quite similar to Dropbox's MVP. However, instead of a video, the smoke test was a minimal landing page. With his two-page MVP, he wanted to determine whether people would consider using the app. In a tweet, Gascoigne asked individuals what they thought of the idea. He received some helpful feedback via email and Twitter and

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considered it ‘validated.’ Then he gained more validated learning.

AMAZON

Amazon is perhaps the best example of a Minimum Viable Product (MVP). In its early days, Amazon sold affordable books online by creating an easy-to-use website. Ultimately, this idea was a hit, and Amazon became one of the biggest brands in eCommerce.

GROUPON

In 2008, the founders of Groupon came up with an idea: What if they shared and socialized the online discount vouchers and deals discovered while shopping? They started with a simple WordPress website, which they used to share Groupons by emailing PDFs of each voucher to subscribers. As their idea for Groupon took off, they hired more people and built a more sophisticated backend process for creating, printing, and sending out the vouchers. One of the best examples of a minimum viable product among startups is their first website.

DROPBOX

Dropbox didn't launch a product. They created an explainer video that showed potential users how the application could work for them. The video was so successful that they got 70,000 email addresses from potential customers in one day.

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HOW MUCH DOES AN MVP COST?

Since there are several key factors involved in the development of an MVP, these factors affect the overall cost of the final MVP.

Such factors can be categorized into:

INITIAL BUDGET TO BUILD AN MVP

You can take different approaches when building an MVP for your business. You can hire product development companies or freelancers, you can also manage the development in-house. Choose whatever approach suits you best — all will require an investment of time and money.

TIME REQUIRED TO BUILD AN MVP

The initial development of an MVP should not take more than two weeks. The first iteration contains the most basic features of an MVP, including an ecosystem map, empathy map, prioritized backlog, user journey map, and stakeholder map. You can expect to pay between $15 and $75 per hour, depending on how complicated the project is.

MVP COST OF DESIGN

The cost of an MVP depends on the amount of design needed. To get a rough estimate of your MVP's design cost,

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evaluate both the user interface and interface experience. A seamless user experience relies on a simple, easily understandable interface and navigation, and all these have a part in determining the cost of an MVP.

NUMBER OF FEATURES AND COMPLEXITY

While building an MVP, two important factors that affect its cost are the complexity of the features and their priority. There is no silver bullet to creating a priority list of features, but two approaches you can use to develop one include the Blue Ocean Strategy and MoSCoW Method.

TECHNOLOGY STACK

Investing in a minimum viable product (MVP) is the first step toward improving your product and boosting your business. However, the exact technology stack that you choose for the MVP depends heavily upon project quality.

For example, Ruby on Rails is ideal for building an MVP's backend because it can be used to build a faster, smarter, and more flexible application. Similarly, React Native allows developers to write code for Android and iOS apps that are almost entirely cross-compatible.

While Ruby on Rails and React Native are powerful frameworks, they may not be ideal for all projects.

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HOW TO REDUCE COSTS OF BUILDING A MINIMAL VIABLE PRODUCT (MVP)

1. PRIORITIZE AND START WITH KEY FEATURES

The first thing you need to do is come up with a list of requirements for each stage of your app's user journey, prioritize all these requirements, and form a product hypothesis. After that, interview potential customers; once you have conducted these interviews, you will know whether your app aligns with market demand or not. You will also know what your users want and how well your app satisfies those needs.

2. CHOOSE CROSS-PLATFORM DEVELOPMENT

If you want to launch a mobile app, you may want to consider cross-platform development as a way of cutting down on software development costs. Native apps require two code bases for each platform. Cross-platform apps only need one codebase.

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It used to be the case that cross-platform options decreased performance and didn't create great user experiences. However, technological innovation has reduced that problem. Flutter is an example of a framework that allows you to build a single codebase that can run on different platforms faster than with native solutions.

Using the same code for different applications can save costs by reducing the need for development, maintenance, and resources. The use of a single codebase means that any modifications to your application can be made quickly to your codebase, which will apply instantaneously to your different platforms.

3. ADOPT A SUITABLE PROJECT MANAGEMENT APPROACH

Next, to keep costs for development under control and ensure a smooth rollout process to the market, you need to select the project management approach that fits your needs.

There are some commonly used approaches — like Agile and Waterfall — but Waterfall often causes projects to take longer, incur greater costs and uncertainties, and can’t accommodate changes in requirements over time. Agile is an iterative approach that includes several smaller cycles. This allows for greater flexibility, reduces development costs, and accelerates returns on investment.

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4. USE CONTINUOUS INTEGRATION AND CONTINUOUS DEPLOYMENT

To reduce development costs and time, it's important to structure your work in a way that enables programmers to automatically build, deploy, and test your app. With the help of a CI/CD pipeline, the entire software building process is automated.

The pipeline includes tests that run every time new code is added to the system (every time you or your team makes changes to the code). A CI/CD pipeline helps ensure that all new code gets tested before it reaches production. With this approach, you can achieve faster product releases, lower expenses, and enhanced software quality.

5. START TESTING EARLY

Have QA testers work with developers early on in the development process to help avoid shipping a glitchy product to the market. By keeping QA testers involved throughout the project, you can significantly cut your development costs by eliminating rework, resolving issues before they become bigger problems, and preventing delays.

6. CHOOSE A PARTNER WITH A TRUSTED IT SERVICE PROVIDER

Of course, it's always best to partner with a reliable contractor when you want to address your business's needs. If you don't work with such a professional, though, you might find yourself

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out of pocket and with a substandard product on your hands. Issues might spring up, like some features not performing as expected while others are riddled with bugs; there might be problems with page-load speed or performance, or even certain parts of the system might not function at all.

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HOW TO CALCULATE THE MVP DEVELOPMENT TIME?

The time it takes to build an MVP depends on many factors. Depending on the complexity of your product idea, you may need to research and analyze what technologies will be most useful, draw up user stories/journeys, and outline specifications. It's also important to design how your product looks, front-end development, back-end development, and testing. Also, don't forget about deployment and marketing.

There are two primary methods for estimating MVP development timeframes:

1. **Agile:** The agile development method is a way of approximating the time required to complete a software project, based on our current understanding of the requirements. It is usually a 'from - to' time frame, and can be modified once you have more information. If you only have an idea that needs to be estimated and developed, and it has not been technically validated yet, you can request the estimation from your outsourcing partner;

2. **Fixed:** The fixed development method has a specific schedule of milestones and requires declarative requirements. It is suitable for startups who want to start development quickly and are very familiar with the project details.

One method may work well for one project, but not another. Which method you choose will depend on how well you

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understand your goal and how clearly you have defined it.

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SHOULD YOU OUTSOURCE THE CREATION OF YOUR MVP?

Because MVPs are so simple, it's pretty easy to build one without having any specialized knowledge, which means that you don't need a highly trained developer to build one. Besides, at this early stage in your startup, you want to spend more time getting money flowing into the company. Plus, depending on your skill set, you might not even be able to write the code for your product. This can make hiring out the development of your MVP more valuable than building it yourself.

A few more factors to consider when deciding between outsourcing or not include:

1. **Cost Reduction:** When you outsource work, you can have it done quickly and cheaply. Compared to hiring an in-house developer, outsourcing is a bargain;

2. **Technical Knowledge:** Development agencies come with knowledgeable and experienced developers who have worked in multiple industries. They can help you decide which features will be right for your product, present you with several perspectives to look at your product from, and they can also provide you with constant support as you build your product;

3. **Faster Turnaround:** A team of hardworking developers

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can help you bring your product or service to market faster. The development process is divided among the team efficiently for better results in less time;

4. **Access to specialists:** Outsourcing allows you to work with people who are experts in their fields. This will allow them to work quickly and efficiently in producing a high-quality product for you.

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MEASURING SUCCESS AFTER BUILDING AN MVP

When you want to know how your software is working out, you should keep your eye on these metrics:

- **Communication:** When promoting software, you should use different forums and talk to visitors. Have them evaluate your product and share their opinions. This will help you to identify problems with the software that you may not have noticed before;
- **User engagement:** User engagement is important to measure because it helps you understand how relevant your product is to potential customers. It also helps you determine your product's potential and detect issues like UX problems;
- **Percentage of paying users:** If you offer a paid subscription to your software, find out who is willing to pay for it and what features they're looking for;
- **The number of downloads:** When it comes to mobile apps, the number of downloads is a key metric. More downloads mean more popularity;
- **Percentage of active users:** The high number of app downloads doesn't mean all customers are active users. You should check out the number of active users, and think about how you can get more customers to be active;

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- **Customer lifetime:** To learn how long users keep your software on their device, monitor the customer lifetime metric. If it is too short, look at other metrics to identify and fix the reason for this.

KEY METRICS TO MEASURE YOUR MVP SUCCESS

Feedback

Customer feedback should be a priority throughout the entire product development life cycle, but it's especially useful in the MVP phase. Interviewing your customers to find out how things are going and what direction your product should take will help you create a successful MVP.

Net promoter score

Net Promoter Score (NPS) is a survey-based metric for measuring customer satisfaction. You can ask your users directly about how good your MVP is by asking them if they would recommend it to others, and rate their experience from 0 to 10.

It's a simple survey: "Will you recommend the product to others?" on an 11-point scale, with zero meaning that the user would not recommend it to anyone and 10 meaning that he or she would recommend it to everyone.

Promoters are users who give scores of 9 or 10, Passives are those who give scores between 7 and 8 (passives are not important though), and Detractors are those who give scores between 0 and 6. The difference between the percentage of promoters and detractors is your NPS score. A successful MVP will have an NPS score significantly above 0.

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Passives are like the hidden gems of customer satisfaction data. If you're a growth-focused marketer, pay attention to how Passives are responding to your brand's efforts; there's a good chance they're not as happy as they could be. The trick is identifying what's making them unhappy and using that as an opportunity to engage with them.

A Passive can be converted into a Promoter if you approach them in the right way; if you don't, they might become a Detractor.

Activations

Activation is a measure of how well your product performs among new users. A startup's success or failure can be determined by how well it does in the beginning. A company that is growing quickly is likely doing a lot of things right. Customers bring revenue, but they also contribute their own experiences, which can help make an organization better.

If companies don't have many new customers coming in, it might mean there's something wrong with either the user experience or the way it markets itself to others.

Active users

The idea of an "active user" can mean different things depending on the product you're building. Mailtrap, for example, defines an active user based on the number of emails a person sends per month: If a person sends at least one email per month, they are counted as an active user. On the other hand, if you're building a messaging app with different social features, something like daily active users would be more appropriate. To measure your company's activity levels, think about which metrics best describe your project.

CAC (Customer Acquisition Cost)

You can measure customer acquisition costs to see how

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much money it takes to get a single customer. The metric is helpful at this stage of a project because it tells whether customers are adopting your solution or not, how much you need to spend on marketing and other expenses to acquire new clients, and whether you're generating enough profit from selling the product.

MRR (Monthly Recurring Revenue)

You should also take into account money-related data when you are creating your product. One of the most important measurements is MRR, or monthly recurring revenue, which is the core financial metric for SaaS products. MRR shows how much money your product makes per month and includes direct income as well as all money-related activities except one-off payments and/or fees.

ARPU (Average Revenue per User)

ARPU — short for “average revenue per user” — is a metric used to gauge a company’s growth performance. ARPU helps determine how many potential users will generate in revenue. To calculate ARPU, divide the total revenue by the total number of users. If you’re selling goods rather than services (and assuming you’re not doing business with affiliates or other similar partners that can decrease or increase your earnings), the formula is mainly the same, but you need to divide the total revenue by the number of customers who purchase your product.

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THE EXISTING ALTERNATIVES TO AN MVP APPROACH

MINIMUM LOVABLE PRODUCT

The minimum viable product (MVP) is a popular approach to new product launches by some companies that create simple, basic functionality. However, few companies consider the downside of the MVP — the potential frustration of the customer, who then looks for an alternative solution.

An alternate approach would be to create just enough features so that customers will love your product from the very beginning. That's where MLP comes in. However, MLPs come with a high upfront investment which can be risky since the product still has chances of falling.

MINIMUM MARKETABLE PRODUCT

A minimum marketable product (MMP) is a potential solution to a problem that has been researched and validated by a customer segment. Thus, MMP implies that you have already established your target users and know the problem you are trying to solve with your product. In this approach, both MLP and MVP are combined to create a product for an existing target audience.

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NEW ALTERNATIVES TO AN MVP, MLP, OR MMP APPROACH

MINIMUM CATCHY OFFER

While a minimum viable product can be a quick solution, a minimum catchy offer is an idea that grabs the attention of your potential customers. A minimum catchy offer can be less complex than an MVP and should be easy to comprehend. One memorable example is when Uber's co-founder, Travis Kalanick, described the service as "push a button, and in five minutes, a car will pick you up and take you wherever you want to go."

As simple as it is, a minimum catchy offer is extremely useful when you are not sure building an MVP is worth it. Depending on how catchy your one-sentence offer is, you can know whether to go on with your product or not.

BLACK HOLE STRATEGY

The black hole strategy is the opposite of the blue ocean strategy. In the latter, you create something new and draw customers to that. Using a black hole strategy, on the other hand, you discover where there are hidden opportunities to influence people who are used to doing things a certain way or simply not doing them.

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LEAN INVESTOR

In the lean investor model, an investor is the first thing needed. If you cannot attract investment, it is a red flag that the business might not be one worth pursuing.

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STEPS TO MOVE FROM MVP TO FULL-SCALE PRODUCT

When you launch your initial product version, it may not have all the features that you expect to have eventually. However, don't let that deter you. After all, the main goal of creating an MVP is to learn about your customers and their needs. So, once you collect enough customer data and feedback and have done enough iterative improvements, plan for a full launch. If done correctly, it should be fairly easy to scale up a product from your MVP. Follow these four steps, to do just that:

COLLECT FEEDBACK

You can figure out how accurate your assumptions are by gathering user feedback. Doing so will help you understand what assumptions about your product were mistaken and what assumptions you were able to validate. As you make adjustments, your product will get better at meeting user expectations.

PREPARE TO SCALE

After a startup launches its Minimum Viable Product (MVP), it needs to be prepared for an increase in new users. Most startups fail to manage their new users properly because they

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are overwhelmed with the flood of interest when they make their MVP public.

GET YOUR PRICING RIGHT

Try different ways of making money from your app, by introducing new premium features or displaying ads. You might discover that ad revenue is more profitable or that more users are willing to pay for your product, for instance, so you can adapt your monetization strategy according to your findings.

MARKET YOUR PRODUCT

When building an MVP, marketing doesn't just involve finding customers to buy your vanilla (feature-poor) product. Instead, successful marketing campaigns seek to gain interest among potential customers by offering a limited number of features, so you can get feedback and add new features in subsequent versions of the product.

ANALYZE AND TEST

While you might have launched the final product, your product will still need improvements here and there, and in some cases, you will have to add more features. All of this can be smoothly achieved and added to your product by performing analysis on changing user tastes and improving your product as needed. After each improvement, tests are still needed to validate them before being pushed out to your users.

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WHAT IS MVP IN MOBILE APPS?

MVP in the mobile app space just like in other spaces refers to an actual app that has limited features that allow it to give early users an experience of what the final product could be. One of the key benefits of an MVP is its ability to test a proposed idea before deciding whether to invest in it further and take it to market. This helps reduce the likelihood of failure by recognizing when there isn't a need for your product.

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HOW TO BUILD MVP APPS

While you now understand why building an MVP mobile app is crucial, you might be confused about how to go about creating one. Here are some tips to help you create an MVP that works for your company.

UNDERSTAND THE MARKET REQUIREMENT

Before you start building an MVP app, it's important to understand the real problem your customers are facing. Your goal is to build the application with core features that solve the identified problem. It's best to identify what the market needs and what your competitors are offering, so you can figure out how to improve upon those features.

You can divide this into two sections: success criteria and long-term goals. Long-term goals will help you plan for improvements in future versions of your app and make the user experience better. Success criteria will help you develop a clear idea of how your app compares to other similar apps in terms of value.

USER JOURNEY

User Journey is the next step when creating a minimum viable product. Your goal is to find out what the user's needs and goals are for the first iteration of your app. Developers

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need to understand what the app will be like for their audience, how they will use it, and so on. Doing this will make it easier to create an application and marketing plan that is in line with your intended audience.

The developers will address the needs of users by defining the order in which they will take action to achieve their goals. They can accomplish this by identifying different categories of users (for example, patients, doctors, nurses, and other healthcare providers). They should identify actions that the different user types need to take (such as browsing through a catalog to buy products), as well as what the outcomes of those actions will be (for instance, seeing a new item on their bill after ordering from an online catalog).

Once these actions and outcomes have been identified, the developers then need to figure out what steps they will take to allow users to reach their goals (receiving the products at a drop-off point).

RESEARCH AND PLANNING

Once the flow of user behavior is understood, you can begin development. Determining what features will add value and solve your audience's problem is key to finding a product-market fit. Estimate the potential of your app, and note the features you can add in future releases. The product roadmap helps you stay focused on working on your MVP app and adding more features as your user base grows.

FEATURES OF THE MOBILE APP

It is now time to add features that an MVP app should have. You can draw up a product roadmap to help you set up your MVP’s features. You need to prioritize the features you want

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and focus on the ones that are important for your users first. After you have come up with some great ideas, you can add in other features later, such as those requested by your user, without it detracting from the overall experience.

It is possible to make an MVP with just a few basic features that cover the core functions of what users want from your product. The best way to start an MVP is by completing your opportunity statement, which helps you get an understanding of what users need and reduce time spent on unnecessary development.

You can break down the product roadmap into smaller milestones that can help you prioritize the project's features. This will enable you to decide on the sequence of your product by ranking each feature by importance and urgency. This makes it easier to implement them, as well as track progress.

DESIGN, DEVELOP AND LAUNCH MVP

After defining and deciding on the core features, the design, development, and launch phase comes next. This phase includes building the essential functionality that makes up the first version of a minimum viable product. The goal is to create a simple product that can be tested for practicality and usefulness. It is easier for developers to use MVP as a tool for continuous testing and improvement. They can make adjustments suggested by customer feedback and product roadmap to ensure the final product meets quality and user standards.

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MVP VALUE ADDITION

The aim of developing a Minimum Viable Product is to create value. To do this, the developer needs to answer a few questions: why would anyone use this product, what are the benefits, etc. The goal is to define the value proposition of the mobile application so that product estimations can be made. Since launching an MVP means the developers will focus on introducing the essential value of the app to users, it's important to outline who the target audience is and build the product around that audience's needs.

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EXAMPLES OF MOBILE APP MVPS THAT ARE NOW MASSIVE SUCCESSES

SPOTIFY

Founded in 2006, the company began to make a name for itself at a time when the music industry was still struggling to adapt to the emerging digital era. Swiftly growing from strength to strength, by 2018 Spotify had achieved more than 90 million subscribers, making it one of the world's most valuable private tech companies, with an estimated value of more than $23 billion.

The Spotify story started as an idea in 2002 as a collaboration between two Swedish entrepreneurs - Daniel Ek, who started as a web developer, and Martin Lorentzon, who already had experience with online music sales. The burgeoning internet offered new opportunities for their project, and together they founded Spotify in Stockholm in 2006. The company expanded rapidly from there onwards thanks to its attention to user feedback, a user-friendly interface, and an almost unparalleled selection of music.

Spotify's ability to follow the "build-measure-learn" cycle and act on user feedback, learn from in-app behavior, and develop a small quality product ensured long-term value and user alignment. Spotify employed the principles of MVP

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development to release iterations of its app, by using them to ensure every addition would delight users.

UBER

Before the existence of apps like Uber, haggling with cab drivers for the best fare was a common and often painful occurrence. Cab drivers and customers alike can agree that the experience is less than ideal, which is why Uber set out to change it.

UberCab allowed customers to connect with cab drivers in real-time and pay them for their service through an electronic transaction. By offering an innovative solution, Uber attracted a lot of attention and gained widespread acceptance among San Francisco consumers. Only after gaining enough user data did Uber begin to include other features.

Over time, Uber expanded to New York, Seattle, Boston, and other large cities. Its developers made features that had been validated in a few cities widespread as it learned more about what commuters wanted. As of today, it offers a wide range of features, including real-time tracking of drivers, automatic credit card payments, and estimates of fares.

INSTAGRAM

In October 2010, Instagram was released as a photo-sharing application. People who downloaded the app could take and edit photos, then add locations to them. Within 24 hours, about 24,000 users signed up for the platform.

Today, Instagram has over one billion monthly active users and 520 million social stories are created daily. Over time, Instagram has changed a lot — video content is now

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supported, direct messaging has been added, and Stories have been developed. As the platform continued evolving over the past twelve years, Instagram eventually became a feature-rich social media platform.

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MINIMUM VIABLE PRODUCT (MVP) IN UX DESIGN

The MVP process works well with Lean UX because designers can use Lean UX techniques to quickly create minimum versions of their designs and test them with users. With the MVP process, designers learn quickly which designs appeal to users.

Lean UX is a circular process of discovery, iteration, learning, and validation. Lean UX differs from the scientific method in that you begin anywhere on the loop and end with a final product. The UX workflow methodology is fairly simple: Prototype, Measure, Learn (repeat based on lessons learned). The Minimum Viable Product (MVP) process is also simple: Build, measure, and learn. The MVP and Lean UX processes are quite similar, so they work hand in hand well.

Here are a few things to have in mind when combining lean UX design and MVPs:

- **Stop Thinking About the Final Product:** While you want to eventually design the best possible solution for your users, it is important to walk through the problem step by step. An overemphasis on the big picture might inhibit creativity and innovation. By walking through the problem, you can find a dozen ways to reach your goals. If you jump ahead and think

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about the final result, you might miss a lot of these potentially better solutions.

Designers can foster more innovative ideas if they stop focusing on their preconceived ideas of what the product should be.

- **Focus on User Needs:** To understand your users, you should try to put yourself in their shoes. Ask yourself, what do they like? What do they care about? What frustrates them? One way to think about user needs is to focus on their pain points— the aspects of their problems that cause them the most distress. By focusing on these points, you can learn more about your customers and come up with more creative solutions.

  Ideally, a designer should try to test their solution with real people as soon as they have an idea of how to solve a problem. This helps them to identify flaws and make adjustments before investing too much time and resources on a product that might not resonate with users. It's also helpful for figuring out what steps or features users want most and how to get them from the point where they are (problem) to the end goal (solution).

- **Think About Necessary Features:** When you're starting a new project, it's a good idea to brainstorm a list of the key features that the final product should have. But keep in mind that what people want from a product is often different from how they phrase their requests.

  Customers will often express their needs based on the benefits they value most, rather than the feature they want exactly. A single benefit may be provided in more than one way. It's up to the designer to determine

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what features are needed to provide each benefit.

It is important to consider both “good” ideas and “bad” ideas when designing a new product. A flawed idea can inspire a better idea, so it’s a good idea to write down every single thought that comes to mind.

Brainstorming as a group can help generate more ideas, such as when someone shares an unexpected solution in the form of a bad idea, another can then mold the idea into a solution. The point of brainstorming is to get all the ideas out of your head and onto paper or a computer screen, regardless of their quality; this helps you be more creative and discover solutions you otherwise wouldn’t have thought about.

Once you have your list of ideas, you can start to narrow them down based on what you have time and money to do. At this point, an MVP — minimum viable product — can be built, and potential users can be tested with it. After which iterative improvements can be made.

- **Building an Initial Lean UX MVP:** Brainstorming and generating ideas are good first steps for creating a lean UX MVP. It's crucial to follow this step by developing a usable product.

  The Lean UX process and the MVP process both aim to create real products quickly. The ultimate goal is to release something that can be tested and provides value to users as soon as possible. But it’s important to consider what features you want in your MVP. You should strive for the minimum number of features users would need to see real value from your product, while still fulfilling original project goals the best they can.

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THE ROLE OF UX IN DEVELOPING AN MVP

To improve user experience, the product team should continue adding refinements to the MVP based on feedback. The key is finding the right balance between useful and useless features. In a way, the dilemma is similar to Goldilocks' explanation: the solution should not be so basic that it is deemed ineffective, nor should it be too complex that it turns users away; the solution must be just right.

The user experience has the power to make or mar your product. You should put yourself in the shoes of your users to develop an MVP that they would like to use, else, you risk running your MVP to the ground.

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HOW THE MVP WAS RUINED

While MVPs are good ways of minimizing cost and saving time during product development, managers are under a lot of pressure to deliver value fast, this however doesn't always have the desired result since it affects product quality adversely.

It is common for managers to use MVPs as an excuse to skimp on quality, which is harmful since it can result in a poor user experience that creates bad word of mouth and makes users churn faster. Still, many developers stretch the boundaries of the definition of "minimum viable product" or simply see it as a way to cut corners. Both parties must be held accountable for achieving the MVP's minimum requirements.

Sometimes managers can make MVPs less effective by treating them as if they were MoSCoW rules. There are four categories of items: "must-haves", "should-haves", "could-haves" and "would-likes"; only the first category is mandatory while the second category is quite important. Several stakeholders may try to push their requests into the first category, causing all the items in that list to remain unresolved.

In extreme cases, more than 60% of requirements can be put into the "musts" category, resulting in some features not making it into a product release. When all the “musts” are crammed in, this sometimes leads to the release of a

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minimum viable product that is barely minimum and in most cases isn't particularly viable.

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CRITICISM OF MVP

- Since MVPs are based on small iterative improvements based on user feedback, it can be a slow process that can allow a competitor to meet and overtake you in your target market;
- Developing an MVP is a complex process, and it can be easy to lose focus while you're working on several iterations of your product;
- Looking for the right technology stack for your MVP can be a hassle sometimes, it can also be expensive, and more or less cause unexpected delays.

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THE MVP IS STILL INCREDIBLY IMPORTANT

It's a shame when managers misuse the idea of minimum viable products. The concept is still an important part of product development. It helps teams develop products based on facts and not unfounded assumptions.

Over the past decade, the tools have improved and are now more powerful than ever before. Therefore, building a small product to try out with customers should be both possible and affordable.

The best way to get it right is to stop using MVPs as prototypes for the final product, and instead use them to test your idea with actual users. Then you can discard what doesn't work by building the real thing. In other words, when someone says they want an MVP, think about how you could build just a small percentage of what they want to test with real customers.

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WHAT COMES AFTER MINIMUM VIABLE PRODUCT

After launching an MVP, you'll get feedback from users that will point you in the right direction. If there is something your users want to be changed, you can do that in a new build of your product. If they want more features altogether, then you can add those new features to the next version of your product. In any case, you will learn from your users, which will lead to more builds with more features.

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CONCLUSION

Adopting an MVP approach can greatly increase the chances of long-term success for your startup. By reducing losses, you save money that might have been spent on a loss-making product or service. Also, it allows you to focus on making your app better and collecting client feedback before even launching your main product.

By using a minimum viable product in business, the product development process will be easier. Be sure to follow the methods outlined, and do not forget that a minimum viable product is built to be iteratively improved over time.

However, you need to have in mind that if your MVP isn't successful, you can either alter your offering or just drop the idea altogether. This puts you in a better position in case of failure instead of building a complete app that fails, leaving you with no capital for another venture.

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